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RUSSIAN ATTACK KILLS 13, WOUNDS 132

A rescuer walks past a damaged building after missile and drone strikes hit Kyiv, Ukraine. **WORLD, A3**

Trump delays Mexico tariffs

President shelves new levies for 90 days as the two countries continue trade talks.

By Patrick J. McDonnell and Steve Padilla

MEXICO CITY — The presidents of Mexico and the United States said Thursday that punishing new tariffs on Mexican exports would be put off for 90 days as the two nations continue negotiations on the contentious levies.

Word of the reprieve came a day after South Korea announced a trade pact with the U.S. and as countries worldwide scrambled to hammer out trade deals by Friday, the day President Trump said new tariffs would take effect.

It was the sole exception to a deadline that Trump said would bring hefty hikes to other, major trading partners of the United States, including Brazil, Canada and India, among dozens of nations that have thus far declined to enter framework trade agreements on strict terms set by the president.

This week, Trump wrote on social media: “THE AUGUST FIRST DEADLINE IS THE AUGUST FIRST DEADLINE — IT STANDS [See Mexico, A4]



FRANCINE ORR Los Angeles Times

RAKEEM ADDISON enters an isolation room at MLK Jr. Hospital in April 2020.

Study: Pandemic aged brain faster, regardless of health

By Rong-Gong Lin II

By almost any measure, living through a once-in-a-century pandemic emergency that killed 7 million people — including 11 million in the U.S. alone — was a harrowing experience.

Now, there’s new evidence suggesting our brains bear the scars of that ordeal.

Living through the pandemic aged our brains faster — even among people who never became sick with COVID-19, according to a recent study.

“Our study suggests that the experience of living through the COVID-19 pandemic was associated with slightly faster brain aging,

even in people who were never infected with the virus,” the study’s lead author, Ali-Reza Mohammadi-Nejad of the University of Nottingham in England, wrote in an email to The Times.

“This effect was subtle but measurable,” he added.

The study, published last month in the journal Nature Communications, wasn’t designed to pinpoint the exact cause of the accelerated brain aging.

“But we believe the cumulative stressors of the pandemic — such as prolonged isolation, disrupted routines, reduced physical and cognitive activity, and economic uncertainty — likely contributed to the observed brain changes,” Mo-

hammadi-Nejad said.

Those factors are all known to influence brain health over time. As the study notes, “it remains unclear whether these brain aging effects may be at least partially reversible.”

Dr. Peter Chin-Hong, a UC San Francisco infectious-disease expert who wasn’t affiliated with the study, said its findings demonstrate “that even if you don’t get infected, all the repercussions of the pandemic — like social isolation and stress — can have an impact on brain health.”

“We know that other things that we do have an impact on brain health, like exercise and diet and sleep,” [See COVID-19, A6]

Utilities fought the removal of old power lines

The Eaton fire ‘could have been prevented,’ says an engineer and former PUC staffer.

By Melody Petersen

The abandoned power line suspected of igniting the Eaton fire could have been removed years ago under a rule proposed by state Public Utilities Commission staffers, but the regulation was weakened amid opposition from Southern California Edison and other utilities, according to records and interviews.

State regulators have long known that old transmission lines could set off wildfires, and in 2001 they proposed a safety rule that would have forced Edison and other electric companies to remove abandoned lines unless they could prove they would use them in the future.

Amid opposition from the utility companies, the Public Utilities Commission studied the proposal for sev-

eral years, ultimately watering it down to allow the old lines to remain up until executives decided they were “permanently abandoned,” records show.

One of those old transmission lines, Edison’s Mesa-Sylmar line that last saw service during the Vietnam War, is at the center of dozens of lawsuits claiming it ignited the devastating Eaton fire on Jan. 7. The inferno roared through Altadena, killing 19 people and destroying 9,400 homes and other structures.

Edison has said a leading theory of the fire’s cause is that the century-old line somehow briefly re-energized, creating an arc that sparked the wildfire. The investigation is continuing.

Raffy Stepanian, an electrical engineer who was part of the commission’s safety team that proposed the 2001 rule to take down abandoned lines, said commission members dialed back the regulation under fierce lobbying by the state’s utilities.

“There was a lot of pres- [See Lines, A8]

Bird flu relief tops \$230 million for state dairy farms

By Susanne Rust

The federal government has paid California dairy farms more than \$230 million to subsidize losses in milk production resulting from bird flu, records show, an amount that the dairy industry expects to climb higher as more claims for damages are processed.

The H5N1 bird flu has swept through more than 75% of California’s 1,000 dairy farms since August 2024, sickening cattle and leading to steep dropoffs in milk production.

Farmers were able to get relief under a U.S. Department of Agriculture program known as the Emer-

gency Assistance for Livestock, Honeybees and Farm-Raised Fish Program, or ELAP. The program usually provides assistance for farmers impacted by wildfires, drought and flooding but was opened up for dairy farmers last year as bird flu began ravaging their cows.

U.S. Department of Agriculture records show that 644 payments were made to 359 California dairy farms between November 2024 and June 2025 totaling \$231 million. The average per farm payment was about \$645,000, and ranged from \$2,058 to the Pereira Dairy Farm, in Visalia, to \$4.4 million to Channel Islands Dairy Farm, in Corcoran. [See Bird flu, A8]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

DAIRIES say USDA relief helps offset bird flu losses, but critics warn the aid could worsen the problem.

Annenberg’s final days saw bitter feud

By Matt Hamilton

In the final weeks of philanthropist Wallis Annenberg’s life, her family and closest friends were consumed by a fierce power struggle over her medical care, court records show.

Three of her children — Gregory, Lauren and Charles — believed their mother was being mistreated during her most vulnerable time, wrongfully confined to her bed, isolated from family and longtime staff and overmedicated to the point of stupor.

They blamed their mother’s longtime partner, Kris Levine, and Kris’ older sister, Vikki Levine.

Vikki, who served as Annenberg’s personal as-

sistant and held authority over her medical decisions, was exerting control over their mother in “likely fatal” ways, hastening her decline with excess narcotics, the children alleged in court documents. The children said they were shielded from information about their mother and were distressed that the Levine sisters had indicated plans to remove Annenberg’s body from her Century City villa within hours of her death and send her remains for composting before a proper goodbye.

“If there is anything suspicious about her death — which is appearing more and more likely given Vikki’s ongoing abuse of Wallis — it will render it impossible to conduct an autopsy,” the children [See Annenberg, A14]

Bands quit Spotify over AI weapons ties

Several artists express alarm at CEO Daniel Ek’s defense funding, pulling their catalogs.

By August Brown

Greg Saunier already had reasons to be wary of Spotify.

The founder of the acclaimed Bay Area band Deerhoof was well acquainted with the service’s meager payouts to artists and songwriters, often estimated around \$3 per thousand streams.

He was unnerved by the service’s splashy pivots into AI and podcasting, where right-wing, conspiracy-peddling hosts like Joe Rogan got multimillion-dollar contracts while working musicians struggled.

But Saunier hit his breaking point in June, when Spotify’s Chief Executive Daniel Ek announced that he’d led a funding round of nearly \$700 million (through his personal investment firm, Prima Materia) into the European defense firm Helsing. That company, which Ek now chairs, specializes in AI software integrated into fighter aircraft like its HX-2 AI Strike Drone.

“Helsing is uniquely positioned with its AI leadership to deliver these critical capabilities in all-domain defense innovation,” Ek said in a statement about the funding round.

In response, Deerhoof pulled its catalog from Spotify. “Every time someone listens to our music on Spotify, does that mean another dollar siphoned off to make all [See Spotify, A12]



NOAM GALAI Getty Images for Spotify

SPOTIFY CEO Daniel Ek announced in June that he’d invested millions into AI defense firm Helsing.

1,350 more Guard troops leave L.A.

Move comes nearly two months after President Trump’s deployment during unrest over ICE raids. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Mystery illness kills Venice dogs

Seven canines have died and 11 more have fallen ill in Canals neighborhood amid the search for answers. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Dodgers improve roster on margins

Team acquires Twins reliever Brock Stewart and Nationals outfielder Alex Call on day of trade deadline. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 84/63. **B6**

